

REACHING OUT



SHAILESHRAVAL

WOONING MINORITIES IS CRUCIAL TO MODI'S CAMPAIGN AGENDA

A secular Narendra Modi may sound like an oxymoron but the elections have compelled the Gujarat chief minister and the BJP's star campaigner to unveil a new persona. Words like "Hindutva" and "Ram Mandir" are no more part of his lexicon. These have been replaced by development, tough governance and an anti-terrorism stance where he is careful to differentiate between terrorism and religion. On his tours across the state, Muslim delegations line up to meet him. His language, to use a favourite phrase of the ruling UPA, is "more inclusive", not divisive. Modi's image makeover is having its effect. When A.I. Saiyad, a former police officer who barely escaped death at the hands of Hindu mobs in 2002 riots in Ahmedabad, recently joined the BJP, several Muslim organisations sent delegations to attend the event. Most political observers say Modi's strategy is centred around winning over the moderate sections of the community while maintaining a tough stance against fundamentalists. Even among the orthodox, he is willing to break bread with those who don't toe the fanatical line. In effect, Modi wants to take along the moderate Barelvi sect of Sunni Muslims while cracking down on ultra Wahabis even as he keeps the door open for moderate Wahabis on his terms. Says Shabbir Alam, the Mufti of Ahmedabad's Jama Masjid, the largest mosque in Gujarat, who is a Barelvi follower: "The Gujarat Government has done good job of keeping the Wahabis on a tight leash. This should have been done much earlier." In keeping with this strategy, all except one member on the State Wakf Board are Barelvis. And moderate Islamic preachers are also being cultivated. Ask Modi about his new romance with the minorities and his standard reply is: "I have always talked about 5.5 crore Gujaratis and that includes all castes and followers of all religions." Not offensive, not rabid, not defensive, not apologetic.

by Uday Mahurkar

Second COMING

There was no waving of the fist and no overtly aggressive gestures. Each and every movement of his was being video-recorded. The BJP's wannabe Hindutva poster boy Varun Gandhi filed his nomination from Pilibhit last week, vowing to protect everyone irrespective of their religion. A much-chastened Varun was at his charming best as he smiled at the cameramen. Wearing a yellow kurta, he came with his mother Maneka Gandhi to file

SANJAY SONKAR



VARUN WITH MANEKA GANDHI

his nomination papers without much fanfare. The scene was in stark contrast to the boisterous parade that accompanied him when he surrendered before a court last month. New Varun posters had sprung up throughout the constituency claiming "main boloonga to bolenge ki bolta hai". His supporters claimed that Varun's yellow kurta was symbolic of the yellow wall built by the Rohillas around the region to protect it from invaders. by Bhavna Vij-Aurora